

Evening Class

Six strangers. Ten weeks. A pottery class. More than clay was shaped.

CEFR Level A2

Book 6 of 9

Adult Graded Reader

Setting: A community arts centre in a small English city. Tuesday evenings, 7-9pm.

Genre: Warm Drama / Community

Characters

- Sol — 52. Secondary school history teacher. Recently divorced. Quiet and observant.
- Priya — 38. GP. Efficient and capable. Doesn't know how to do something badly yet.
- Dennis — 67. Retired plumber. Widower. Has good hands.
- Amelia — 24. Graphic design student. Already knows what she likes.
- Yusuf — 45. Restaurant owner. Has too many ideas.
- Gill — 58. Admin manager. Signed up on impulse. Not sure why she came.

The arts centre was on a side street near the market square.

Sol arrived seven minutes early, which was his habit, and stood in the corridor until the room was unlocked. He had signed up for the evening pottery class three weeks ago, on a Tuesday evening when he had been sitting in his empty flat and could not think of a single reason not to.

The instructor — a woman called Kate — opened the door at five to seven.

'Come in,' she said. 'There's clay on the tables and aprons on the hooks. Pick a wheel.'

Sol picked the one nearest the window.

An empty flat. A pottery class. A wheel by the window. What is Sol looking for?

By seven o'clock, all six students were at their wheels.

On Sol's left was a young woman who introduced herself as Amelia. On his right was a large, quiet man named Dennis, who had brought his own apron.

Across the room were three others: Priya, who had arrived with a new notebook; Yusuf, who had immediately started talking about Japanese ceramics; and Gill, who was sitting very still and looking at the clay as if it might do something unexpected.

Kate began the first lesson: centering.

Centering, Kate explained, was the foundation of everything. Before you could shape anything, you had to get the clay perfectly centred on the wheel.

'If it's off-centre,' she said, 'everything you make will wobble and collapse.'

She made it look easy. It was not easy.

After twenty minutes, Priya's clay had wobbled, collapsed twice, and was now a flat disc that she was staring at with the expression of someone who did not understand why the world wasn't cooperating. Sol's was better — barely. Dennis's was almost perfect. 'How?' Sol asked.

Dennis shrugged. 'Good hands,' he said. 'Plumbing.' By week three, they had stopped being strangers. Not friends yet — but the kind of people who save each other the same wheel every week without discussing it. Yusuf brought food on the third Tuesday — small pastries from his restaurant. Nobody objected. Priya had stopped bringing her notebook.

'I realised I couldn't write and centre at the same time,' she told Sol.

Sol laughed. 'That's how it works,' he said. 'You have to choose.'

Priya looked at him. 'Is that a metaphor?' 'Probably,' Sol said.

Dennis did not talk much. But when he did, it was worth listening to.

In week four, while they were trimming their first pots, Gill asked him what his wife thought of him doing pottery.

Dennis was quiet for a moment. 'She died three years ago,' he said. 'Maggie. She always wanted to do a class like this. We kept putting it off.'

The room was quiet.

'So you came anyway,' Gill said.

'Yes,' Dennis said. He turned his pot slowly on the wheel. 'Better late than never. That's what she would have said.'

In week five, Priya's pot finally stayed centred.

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Sol arrives early for the evening pottery class.

She raised both hands in the air when it happened. Then she looked slightly embarrassed about having done so.

'That's what I'm talking about,' Kate said.

After the class, Sol walked with Priya to the car park.

'How long have you been a GP?' he asked.

'Twelve years.' 'Is it always like that — needing everything to work?'

Priya thought. 'Mostly. In medicine, things have to go right. People's lives depend on it.' She unlocked her car. 'This is the first time in years I've done something that was allowed to go wrong.'

Amelia was the youngest and the most technically skilled from the start.

By week five, she was already making tall, elegant forms while the others were still working on basic bowls.

In week six, Kate challenged her.

'You're making things that look like you already know what you want,' Kate said. 'For this week, make something you don't know how to make.'

Amelia looked uncertain. 'Like what?' 'Anything,' Kate said. 'Start without a plan.'

Amelia sat at her wheel for five minutes without touching the clay.

It was, Sol noticed, the longest she had been still all term.

In week six, during the break, Sol asked Gill why she had signed up.

Gill had been quiet all term — not unfriendly, but contained.

'I had a breast cancer scare,' she said. She said it plainly, as a fact. 'Everything turned out fine. But it made me think — I need to do something that's just mine. Not for work. Not for my family. Just for me.'

Sol nodded. 'And pottery was the answer?'

Gill smiled. 'I nearly signed up for salsa dancing. But this seemed less likely to injure anyone.'

Week seven was glazing week.

Kate brought out the glazes — dozens of colours in small pots, each labelled.

The students looked at them with the same expression people have in front of a menu when everything sounds good.

Yusuf was immediately decisive: 'Terracotta, celadon, and white. Classic.'

Amelia took thirty minutes, sitting very still, considering.

Dennis chose the same blue he had chosen for everything. When Sol asked why, Dennis said: 'Maggie's favourite colour.'

In week eight, while they were waiting for the kiln results, Sol told the group he was divorced.

He hadn't planned to. It just came out.

'Last January,' he said. 'Seventeen years. We grew apart, I suppose. Or I grew in the wrong direction.'

Nobody said anything unhelpful. Amelia nodded. Yusuf refilled everyone's tea.

Dennis said: 'The first year is the worst. Then it's just different.'

Gil said: 'Are you doing all right?' Not 'I'm sorry' — just that.

Sol looked at his tea. 'I think so,' he said. 'I'm here, aren't I?'

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Six strangers begin learning with clay and conversation.

In week nine, the kiln results came back.

Some pots had cracked. Priya's first pot — the one that had taken five weeks to centre — had a small crack running along the base.

She looked at it for a long moment.

'I'm going to keep it,' she said.

'Why?' Amelia asked. 'It's broken.' 'Yes,' Priya said. 'But it's the first thing I've made. I want to remember that it was hard.'

Kate overheard this. 'That's called kintsugi thinking,' she said. 'The Japanese art of repairing broken things with gold. The crack is part of the history.'

Dennis's pot had come out beautifully. Blue glaze, smooth sides, perfectly balanced.

Kate held it up for the class. 'This is what centering looks like in the final object,' she said.

Dennis took it carefully.

'Are you going to use it?' Yusuf asked.

'No,' Dennis said. 'I'm going to put it on the shelf in the kitchen. Maggie collected things like this. Blue things.'

He wrapped it in paper and put it in his bag.

Later, Sol thought about that blue pot on a kitchen shelf. It seemed like the most complete thing he had heard all term.

In the final week, Kate asked each student to bring their best piece and talk about it.

Yusuf brought a wide, flat bowl — patterned with his own design, inspired by tile work he had seen in Morocco.

Amelia brought her most recent piece: something unexpected, asymmetric, nothing like her earlier work.

'I still don't know what it is,' she said. 'But I like it.'

Kate smiled. 'That's progress,' she said.

Gill brought a small mug. 'It's for my morning coffee,' she said. 'That's enough.'

Sol's piece was a bowl — not particularly impressive technically, slightly uneven on one side.

He held it up. 'This is the third bowl I made,' he said. 'The first two collapsed. This one stayed together. I don't know why this one worked and the others didn't.' 'Sometimes things just hold,' Dennis said.

The others were quiet.

Sol looked at the bowl. It had a faint shadow on the inside from where his thumb had pressed too hard. 'I'm keeping it,' he said. 'To remember that things can hold.'

After the last class, they went to the pub across the road.

They stayed for two hours.

Yusuf told them about his first restaurant — a terrible, wonderful disaster.

Dennis told them about a plumbing job in the 1990s that had flooded an entire office building.

Priya told them about her worst day in the surgery.

Amelia told them about failing her first year at art school.

Gill told them about the two weeks she had spent waiting for biopsy results.

Sol listened to all of it. He said very little. He thought: this is what people sound like when they stop performing.

"This is what people sound like when they stop performing." The pub after pottery.

Walking home, Sol fell into step with Gill.

'I'm glad I signed up,' she said.

'Me too,' Sol said.

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Over ten weeks, the class shapes more than pottery.

'I almost didn't,' Gill said. 'I thought — what's the point? You go, you make some wobbly pots, you go home.'

'And?' 'And it was still that. Wobbly pots. But also other people. And it turns out other people is the point.'

Sol thought about this as he walked the rest of the way home.

His flat was cold when he got in. He put the bowl on the kitchen table.

It was small and slightly uneven. It held the light well.

Three weeks later, Sol received an email from the arts centre.

Evening pottery — new term. Tuesdays, 7–9pm.

Bookings now open.

He booked immediately.

The following Tuesday, he arrived seven minutes early.

The same corridor. The same room. New aprons on the hooks.

Three of the others were already there: Gill, Dennis, and Priya.

They didn't say much. They just took their usual wheels.

Sol took the one by the window.

In the second term, things were different.

Not in obvious ways. They still made wobbly pots. Kate still had to tell Yusuf to simplify his ideas.

But the silences were different. Comfortable instead of careful.

And they talked more freely.

Priya talked about a difficult case at the surgery — not asking for advice, just talking.

Dennis brought photographs of Maggie. They were passed around the table, carefully.

Amelia showed them a project she had submitted for her degree. She had never shown anyone her work before.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story. They are given together so the reading pages stay like a real story book.

1. arts centre	sanat merkezi
2. corridor	koridor
3. apron	önlük
4. wheel	çömlekçi çarkı
5. instructor	eğitmen
6. on impulse	dürtüsellekle
7. introduced herself	kendini tanıttı
8. ceramics	seramik
9. centering	merkezleme (çömlek tekniği)
10. unexpected	beklenmedik
11. notebook	defter
12. foundation	temel
13. wobble	sallanmak
14. collapse	çökmek
15. off-centre	merkezden sapık
16. disc	disk, çember
17. cooperating	işbirliği yapıyor
18. save each other	birbirine saklıyor
19. objected	itiraz etti
20. metaphor	mecaz, metafor
21. realised	fark etti
22. probably	muhtemelen
23. trimming	kesme, düzeltme
24. kept putting it off	ertelemeye devam etti
25. better late than never	geç olsun güç olmasın
26. would have said	demiş olurdu
27. anyway	yine de
28. embarrassed	utanmış
29. car park	otopark
30. allowed to go wrong	yanlış gitmesine izin verilen
31. depend on	... e bağlı
32. finally stayed centred	sonunda merkezde kaldı
33. technically skilled	teknik açıdan yetenekli
34. elegant	zarif
35. uncertain	emin değil
36. without a plan	plansız
37. all term	tüm dönem boyunca
38. challenge	meydan okumak

39. scare	korku, panik
40. plainly	açıkça, sade bir şekilde
41. contained	içe kapalı
42. injure	yaralamak
43. turned out fine	iyi sonuçlandı
44. just mine	sadece benim
45. glazing	sırlama
46. glazes	sırlar
47. terracotta	kiremit rengi
48. celadon	açık yeşil seramik rengi
49. decisive	kararlı
50. favourite colour	en sevdiği renk
51. divorced	boşandı
52. grew apart	birbirinden uzaklaştı
53. unhelpful	yardımcı olmayan
54. refilled	doldurdu
55. kiln	fırın, ocak
56. in the wrong direction	yanlış yönde
57. cracked	çatlamış
58. crack	çatlak
59. base	taban
60. overheard	kulak misafiri oldu
61. kintsugi	altın onarım sanatı
62. repair	onarmak
63. glaze	sır
64. balanced	dengeli
65. wrapped in paper	kağıda sardı
66. kitchen shelf	mutfak rafı
67. collected things	şeyler biriktirdi
68. complete	eksiksiz
69. asymmetric	asimetrik
70. inspired by	... den ilham alan
71. tile work	çini işçiliği
72. progress	ilerleme
73. enough	yeterli
74. uneven	düzensiz, eğri
75. faint shadow	hafif iz
76. pressed	bastırdı

77. held up	yukarı kaldırdı
78. hold	tutmak, dayanmak
79. stayed together	bir arada kaldı
80. disaster	felaket
81. flooded	su bastı
82. biopsy	biyopsi
83. performing	performans sergilemek
84. worst day	en kötü gün
85. waiting for results	sonuçları beklemek
86. fell into step with	yanında yürümeye başladı
87. what's the point	ne faydası var
88. turns out	ortaya çıktı
89. held the light	ışığı tutuyordu
90. wobbly	sallantılı
91. bookings now open	rezervasyonlar açıldı
92. new term	yeni dönem
93. booked immediately	hemen yer ayırttı
94. usual wheels	her zamanki çarklar
95. corridor	koridor
96. obvious ways	belirgin şekillerde
97. freely	özgürce
98. comfortable	rahat
99. submitted	teslim etti
100. passed around	el ele dolaştırıldı
101. simplify	basitleştirmek

After-Reading Activities

Page 19 — Yusuf's Bowl

In the seventh week of the second term, Yusuf finished a bowl that surprised even him.

It was simple — far simpler than his usual work.

Pale grey glaze. Clean lines. Nothing added.

'I was going to add a pattern,' he said. 'But then I thought — maybe not everything needs more.'

Kate looked at it for a long time. 'That's the best thing you've made,' she said.

Yusuf sat with that for a moment.

'In the restaurant,' he said slowly, 'I always think everything needs more. More flavour. More texture. More.' He paused. 'Maybe not always.'

Vocabulary Support

pale grey

açık gri

clean lines

temiz hatlar

texture

doku

flavour

lezzet

surprised even him

kendini bile şaşırttı

simple

sade

"Maybe not always." Yusuf learns something from clay that he needed for his kitchen.

Page 20 — The Bowl on the Table

Sol's first bowl was still on his kitchen table.

He had bought a small plant and put it in the bowl.

Not a flower — just a little green thing from the

market.

He thought about the ten weeks of the first term.

About what he had been looking for when he walked in.

He hadn't been looking for anything specific. He had just needed somewhere to be.

He had found: Dennis, Priya, Gill, Yusuf, Amelia.

Clay. Tuesday evenings.

He had found that things can hold — bowls, and other things.

He went to get ready for class. He left seven minutes early, as always.

Vocabulary Support

plant

bitki

somewhere to be

bulunacak bir yer

specific

belirli

hold

tutmak, dayanmak

get ready

hazırlanmak

as always

her zaman olduğu gibi

"Somewhere to be." And he found it. Tuesday evenings. The wheel by the window.

Answer Key

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word with the correct meaning.

Word

Meaning

1. centering

A. önlük

2. apron

B. merkezleme

3. wobble

C. sallanmak

4. glaze

D. fırın

5. kiln

E. sır

6. asymmetric

F. asimetrik

7. kintsugi

G. altın onarım sanatı

8. performing

H. performans sergilemek

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word from the box and write it in the blank.

centred — crack — allowed — point — hold — changed

1. If the clay is off-centre, everything you make will wobble and _____.

2. Priya's pot had a _____ in it — but she kept it because it was her first.

3. Priya said pottery was the first thing she had done that was _____ to go wrong.